Moving MFA to a new phone

Article KB0010008 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: MFA / authenticator | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 laptops (MacBook Pro/Air), iOS and Android smartphones, Microsoft Authenticator app, Microsoft Entra ID (Azure AD) and on-prem Active Directory

Summary

This article guides Acme Global employees through moving their Microsoft Authenticator MFA registration to a new smartphone, whether they still have access to the old device or need help from the Service Desk. It provides a self-help procedure for users who can still approve MFA, verification steps to confirm the new setup works, and a detailed agent procedure for Identity & Access Management to reset MFA registration when the old phone is unavailable.

Symptoms

- "We didn't get a response from the authenticator app"
- "Authentication failed"
- "The verification code is incorrect"
- Push notification not received on the phone
- Authenticator app shows the wrong account or no account
- Unable to sign in to Outlook, Teams, or other M365 services due to MFA prompt

Common causes

- Phone replaced, lost, or stolen
- Authenticator app time not synchronized with the server
- Backup SMS method not configured or unavailable
- Existing MFA registration tied to the old device only
- Temporary Access Pass expired or not issued

User Self-Help: Move MFA to a New Phone (when you still have access to the old device or backup SMS)

If you can still approve an MFA push on your old phone or receive the backup SMS code, you can re-register the Authenticator app on your new phone yourself. This process replaces the old device registration with the new one while keeping your account secure.

1. Ensure you have either:
- The old phone nearby and able to receive a push notification, or
- Access to the backup SMS method (the phone number on file).
2. Install the Microsoft Authenticator app from the Apple App Store or Google Play Store on your new smartphone.
3. Open the Authenticator app, choose "Add account" -> "Work or school account", and sign in with your Acme Global email address (username@acme.example).
4. You will be prompted to approve the sign-in. Do one of the following:
- Tap "Approve" on the old phone's push notification, **or**
- Enter the backup SMS code sent to your registered phone number.
5. After approval, the app will finish registering your new device. The old phone entry is automatically removed from your MFA methods.
6. Test the new registration by signing into a service that requires MFA (e.g., Outlook Web at https://outlook.office.com). Accept the push notification on your new phone to confirm it works.

Verification: Confirm MFA Works on the New Device

After completing the self-help steps, perform a quick check to make sure the new device is the only active MFA method and that you can successfully authenticate. This helps avoid future lock-outs and ensures the backup SMS method remains functional if needed.

1. Sign out of any Microsoft 365 session (e.g., close Outlook, Teams, or browser windows).
2. Open a private/incognito browser window and go to https://portal.office.com.
3. Enter your Acme Global email address and password when prompted.

4. When the MFA prompt appears, verify that you receive a push notification **only** on your new phone (or the SMS code if you rely on backup).
5. Approve the notification or enter the code; you should gain access to the portal without errors.
6. Optional: Review your registered authentication methods in the My Account portal (https://myaccount.microsoft.com/security) to confirm the new phone is listed and the old device is absent.

Service Desk Agent Procedure: Reset MFA Registration (Identity & Access Management)

When a user cannot approve MFA on their old phone and has no backup SMS access, the Service Desk must verify the user's identity, clear the existing Authenticator registration, and either guide the user through self-service re-registration or issue a Temporary Access Pass (TAP). Follow the steps below to resolve the ticket securely and within SLA.

1. 1. **Identity verification** - Confirm the user's identity using an alternate method approved by IAM (e.g., manager confirmation, government-issued photo ID shown via video call, or pre-shared secret). Document the verification method in the ticket.
2. **Locate the user in Microsoft Entra ID** - Go to the Azure portal -> Azure Active Directory -> Users, search for the user's UPN, and open their profile.
3. **Remove the existing Authenticator method** - Under "Authentication methods", find the Microsoft Authenticator entry and select "Delete". Confirm the action.
4. **Force re-registration** - Still in the user's authentication methods page, enable the option "Require re-register multi-factor authentication at next sign-in" (or simply note that deleting the method will trigger this at next login).
5. **Communicate with the user** - Inform the user to install Microsoft Authenticator on their new smartphone and await the MFA prompt during their next sign-in attempt.
6. **If the user cannot receive any MFA** - Issue a Temporary Access Pass:
   - In the same user profile, select "Temporary access passes" -> "New Temporary access pass".
   - Set a suitable lifetime (e.g., 60 minutes) and enable "One-time use" if appropriate.
   - Copy the generated pass and send it to the user via a secure channel (e.g., encrypted email or Teams chat).
   - Instruct the user to sign in at https://mysignins.microsoft.com/security-info, choose "Sign in with a temporary access pass", enter the pass, and then complete the Authenticator registration on the new device.
7. **Confirm successful registration** - Ask the user to verify they can approve a push notification on the new phone (or use backup SMS). Once confirmed, close the ticket and note the steps taken and verification outcome in the resolution notes.
8. **Update documentation** - If the user enabled backup SMS during this process, remind them to verify the phone number is correct in the My Account portal for future resilience.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team lead or Security Operations if:
- The user's identity cannot be verified with reasonable confidence (e.g., conflicting information, potential social engineering).
- Multiple failed MFA reset attempts suggest a compromised account.
- The user reports that the Authenticator app shows an unfamiliar account or that they suspect credential theft.
When escalating, include:
- Ticket number and user UPN.
- Summary of identity verification steps performed and outcomes.
- Any relevant screenshots or logs (e.g., sign-in attempts, Authenticator error codes).
- Requested action (e.g., force password reset, review of sign-in risk, or issuance of a new TAP with extended lifetime).

Keywords: MFA, multi-factor authentication, Authenticator, new phone, lost phone, backup SMS, temporary access pass, TAP, reset MFA, re-register Authenticator, Identity & Access Management, IAM, Entra ID, Azure AD, phone change, device swap, push notification, verification code